

The Cardinal's Promise – Editorial Assessment Summary

The roadmap points to a consistent pattern in the back half of the manuscript:

- The manuscript is strongest when it stays in scene.
- Lou's actions carry more weight than explanations about Lou.
- Hospice is most effective when readers experience it through patients and families rather than through definitions.
- The final third does not need major restructuring; it needs selective tightening and trust in what is already on the page.

Revision Priorities

1. What He Didn't Owe — largest opportunity for compression.
2. The Line — reduce hospice-explanation passages.
3. The Finish Line — trim resume-style summary material.
4. Five Weeks — consider modest expansion of bedside and family scenes.
5. Global pass — remove repeated explanations of recovery, belonging, and why Lou mattered.

The emotional spine from West Palm Beach to Carrabba's to Chumuckla to Hope to Five Weeks to Fifteen Days is already present. The editorial work is mostly about clearing away material that explains what the reader has already felt.